



F1 2011

Formula 1



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Formula One is a sport considered by many aficionados to represent the pinnacle of the motor racing experience. The cars themselves are marvels of precision engineering – every aspect of the vehicles is fine-tuned to an almost impossible degree of perfection. A sport where an ounce of extra weight might mean the difference between finishing on the podium or among the also-rans. Codemasters have set themselves quite a lofty goal as they try to recreate this experience and, all things considered, have succeeded to a very large extent.

Start your engines!

Visually, the game has received a very subtle but noticeable boost to the graphics engine. Compared to its predecessor, the colours are brighter now and the environments don't look as drab and washed out as they used to. The cars are also much shinier and have far more visual detail. The steering wheels are now unique to each car and have been modelled to represent the exact design and layout used by each team. Subtle animations such as the vibrations of the front wing as you take a corner

at speed, smoking tyres as you lock your wheels up in an attempt to hit that apex and the driver's interaction with his steering wheel as you adjust your car settings or engage DRS or KERS go a really long way towards improving game immersion.

The audio has received a major boost as well. The engine notes are far more accurate and you can actually tell when to change gear by just listening to the engine notes, or even "hear" the wind whistling by your ears as you go hurtling down a long strait with your DRS flap wide open!

F1 2010, while a good game, always felt a little bland. The damage was very minimal and the start of a race was nowhere near as chaotic as that of an actual race. The engine notes were quite tame and you could go flying around any corner safe in the knowledge that you would not spin out that easily, despite turning off the driving assists. F1 2011 has sought to remedy all that. The car handling is far more realistic now, you can't just go pedal-to-the-metal the entire length of the race. Finer, gradual inputs are rewarded and even required at higher difficulty levels. In fact, playing the game with just a keyboard will be an exercise in frustration when the driving assists are off. A dab of the throttle as you navigate a steep curve and you'll end up facing the

THE SKOAR

8

Genre: Racing

Developer: Codemasters Birmingham

Publisher: Codemasters

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way you came. At the very least, you would require a gamepad with analog triggers to ensure you have the car under control at all times. The wheels actually lock-up under heavy braking and you will need to monitor them for flat spots as well as tyre wear. Your engineer is also more helpful this time around. He actually provides you with relevant information as you race and doesn't pester you with irrelevant inanities.

One slight niggle here is still the damage modelling. While an improvement over the original game, it is still nowhere near as good as it should be. F1 cars are made of some of the strongest and lightest materials available, but they are also incredibly fragile and sensitive as well. This just doesn't come across in the game. You can happily go around bumping into walls and other cars and only suffer the loss of the front wing.

The game plays out very much like its predecessor, you are a rookie driver starting your F1 career off in one of the lesser teams. You work your way up by completing mission objectives throughout your career and receive vehicle updates and team offers based on your performance and handling of the press. A very nice new addition here is the inclusion of support for an actual human team-mate as you go through your career. The two of you can play via split-screen, LAN or online.

Parc Ferme

Overall F1 2011 is a worthy upgrade over its predecessor. Think of it as upgrading from Windows Vista to Windows 7. Both of them essentially share the same core, but the slight tweaks and upgrades put F1 2011 in a different league altogether. The formula isn't perfect yet and it is still far from delivering the definitive Formula One experience, but judging by the way Codemasters is working on it, they are getting there. ✱

